
*A COMPREHENSIVE ANALYSIS OF THE
EDUCATION IN WEST BENGAL IN 1994-’95*

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Abstract

This research paper delves into the intricate evolution of school education in West Bengal, tracing its historical roots, key milestones, and transformative phases. It offers a comprehensive analysis spanning multiple decades, examining the socio economic and cultural factors that have shaped the educational landscape in the region.

The paper critically evaluates the evolution of curriculum frameworks, pedagogical approaches, and the integration of technology in classrooms. It also scrutinizes challenges such as infrastructure disparities, access to quality education in rural areas, teacher training, and educational equity.

The report showcases recent educational developments, yet points out that disparities still exist, such as the insufficient number of schools and challenges faced in higher education.

Ultimately, this analysis aims to contribute valuable insights for educators, and stakeholders, offering recommendations to further enhance the quality and effectiveness of school education in West Bengal.

I. Introduction

Education stands as the cornerstone of societal progress, shaping the future of the new generation. In the context of West Bengal, the evolution of its education system mirrors a complex interplay of historical legacies, socio-economic transitions and collective efforts towards progress. This research endeavours to dissect and comprehend this intricate journey, offering a comprehensive analysis that traverses the diverse epochs that have sculpted West Bengal's educational landscape.

This study embarks on an exploration of this educational journey, aiming to dissect the contours of change across decades. It scrutinizes the pivotal moments that defined the trajectory of education in the state. From examining the structural reforms in curriculum design and pedagogical methodologies to the integration of technology in classrooms, this research delves into the multifaceted dimensions that have shaped the educational sphere.

Furthermore, this analysis extends beyond the textbooks and classrooms to address the practical challenges ingrained within the system. Issues of educational equity, disparities in infrastructure between urban and rural areas, the quality of teacher training, and the ever-evolving quest for inclusivity form crucial facets of this exploration.

II. Objectives

- **Historical Exploration:** Trace the historical roots of school education in West Bengal, examining its inception during colonial rule and subsequent developmental phases.
- **Policy Analysis:** Evaluate key educational policies, reforms, and initiatives implemented in West Bengal across different periods and their impact on the educational system.
- **Pedagogical Examination:** Analyse changes in pedagogical approaches, curriculum frameworks, and teaching methodologies over time and their implications for student learning.
- **Societal and Cultural Influences:** Explore how societal norms, cultural values, and political movements have influenced the evolution of school education in West Bengal.

III. Methodology

This section of the report typically includes the research design, data collection methods, analysis techniques, tools used, and any limitations encountered during the study.

1. Research Design: This study employed a mixed-methods research design to gather both quantitative and qualitative data. The combination of survey data and in-depth interviews allowed for a comprehensive understanding of the research topic.

2. Data Collection: We are not able to construct any kind of survey henceforth we collected some secondary data about demographic information and opinions on the topic.

3. Data Analysis: All the information were analysed using descriptive statistics.

4. Tools and Instrument: Descriptive statistics was used for quantitative data analysis due to its robust statistical capabilities.

IV. Results and Discussion

Table-1: Distribution of literacy by sex and districts

Year	1981		1991		1981		1991	
Sex	Male	Female	Male	Female	Male	Female	Male	Female
District					Percentage		Percentage	
Burdwan	1307145	744668	1910272	1226489	9.16	9.46	9.51	9.80
Birbhum	254791	251316	632311	372463	1.79	3.19	3.15	2.98
Bankura	627675	282676	800559	416115	4.40	3.59	3.98	3.32
Midnapur	1920232	961208	2869360	1884920	13.45	12.21	14.28	15.06
Howrah	962584	562010	1291620	851686	6.74	7.14	6.43	6.80
Hooghly	1080884	654598	1471726	1005512	7.57	8.32	7.32	8.03
N_24-Parganas	3147288	1810795	2434721	1693972	22.05	23.00	12.12	13.53
S_24-Parganas			1651085	899652			8.22	7.19
Calcutta	1418245	866247	1827195	1260703	9.94	11.00	9.09	10.07
Nadia	666238	422046	1000807	686090	4.67	5.36	4.98	5.48
Murshidabad	599239	321264	899266	535186	4.20	4.08	4.48	4.28
West Dinajpur	449689	199692	650678	334704	3.15	2.54	3.24	2.67
Malda	327808	140728	492770	251048	2.30	1.79	2.45	2.01
Jalpaiguri	432566	213865	668408	363510	3.03	2.72	3.33	2.90
Darjeeling	281564	153443	387248	249289	1.97	1.95	1.93	1.99
Coachbehar	366965	167381	523981	282126	2.57	2.13	2.61	2.25
Purulia	430132	120170	579829	204096	3.01	1.53	2.89	1.63
Total	14273045	7872107	20091836	12517561	64.45	35.55	61.61	38.39

Source: Census of India 1991.
Series – 1, Paper – 2 of 1992

The Table-1 displays the total literacy in from census data 1991. The literacy rate in West Bengal is 50.1% in 1981, where, male literacy rate 64.45% and female 35.54%. The literacy rate in West Bengal is 46.6% in 1991, where, male literacy rate 61.61% and female 38.38%.

Table-2: Number of schools in West bengal by districts

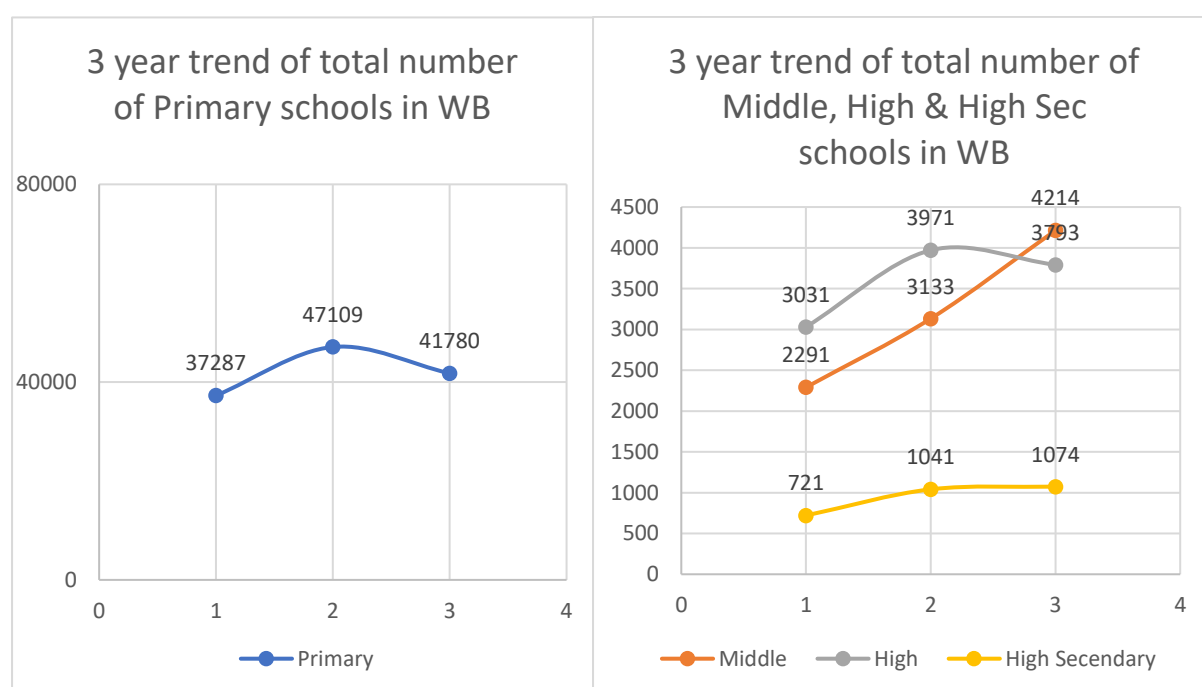
	1987-'88				1988-'89				1989-'90			
	Primary	Middle	High	High Secondary	Primary	Middle	High	High Secondary	Primary	Middle	High	High Secondary
District												
Burdwan	3775	226	422	115	3775	235	427	120	3775	236	427	120
Birbhum	-	-	-	-	2351	110	213	45	-	1484	238	136
Bankura	3372	147	209	57	3185	186	-	-	3185	186	-	-
Midnapur	7652	612	618	120	7675	626	623	121	7675	586	632	128
Howrah	2208	172	270	74	2208	172	270	76	2218	172	272	76
Hooghly	2976	211	326	90	2976	211	326	90	2999	208	332	90
N_24-Parganas	-	-	-	-	3722	332	475	159	3722	333	476	180
S_24-Parganas	-	-	-	-	3733	355	429	96	3733	255	429	96
Calcutta	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-
Nadia	2342	150	218	38	2366	160	222	56	2373	160	222	56
Murshidabad	2837	163	234	53	2887	161	245	53	2897	162	254	52
West Dinajpur	2508	123	144	23	2602	108	149	29	2602	108	149	29
Malda	1891	110	152	28	1873	102	152	72	-	-	-	-
Jalpaiguri	1935	99	123	33	1954	99	123	34	1954	104	124	37
Darjeeling	1145	55	83	22	1154	55	83	22	-	-	-	-
Coachbehar	1734	97	106	22	1734	95	108	22	1742	94	112	24
Purulia	2912	126	126	46	2914	126	126	46	2905	126	126	50

Source: Directorate of school education, Govt of West Bengal.

The Table 2 displays the district wise number of schools in West Bengal as the per 1991 census.

As per the Table-2 and Table-1, it illustrates the literacy rates of the districts are increased year wise as the number of schools were increased year by year, the Table – 2 stated no data collected for Calcutta for every year 1987-1990, and N-24-parganas & S-24-Parganas for 1987-'88 and Malda & Darjeeling for 1989-'90. Apart from this, the great number of schools present in Midnapur district for all in primary, middle, high and high secondary and the lowest number of schools present in Darjeeling.

Chart-1: Line diagram shows the total number of schools



The data shows the growth of different types of schools in West Bengal from 1987 to 1990. It seems that primary schools had the highest number and the fastest growth rate, followed by middle schools. High and high secondary schools had lower numbers and slower growth rates. This could indicate that more children were enrolled in primary education, but fewer of them continued to higher levels of schooling.

Some possible reasons for this trend are:

1. Lack of access or affordability of higher education for rural or poor students.
2. High dropout rates due to socio-economic factors, such as child labour, early marriage, or gender discrimination.
3. Low quality or relevance of curriculum and teaching methods at higher levels of education.
4. Insufficient infrastructure or resources for higher education, such as classrooms, teachers, or textbooks.
5. These are some of the challenges that the education sector in West Bengal might face in ensuring equitable and quality education for all.

Table-3: Total literate population by age group in Midnapore district

Midnapore					
Age group	Total	Male	Percentage	Female	Percentage
0-4	-	-	-	-	-
5-9	280556	159177	5.53	121379	4.22
10-14	590691	345587	12.01	245104	8.51
15-19	419404	251555	8.74	167849	5.83
20-24	373273	239680	8.33	133593	4.64
25-29	298365	200808	6.98	97557	3.39
30-34	210330	148145	5.15	62185	2.16
35-59	577965	458976	15.94	118989	4.13
60+	127975	114080	3.96	13895	0.48
Total	2878559		66.63		33.37

Source: Census of India, 1981, Series 23, part IVA, Social and cultural tables.

Table-3 presents the age group wise literate distribution of the total population of Midnapore district of West Bengal. Out of the total population from all age groups (except less than 4 years of age, because those ages child are not able for admission in formal education) 66.63% people are male and 33.37% of people are female among the total population of Midnapore district, West Bengal.

Table-3 stated the male literacy is higher than the female literacy rates, which stated that in the peoples of Midnapore has no gender biases on child reproductive case but in case of education there have gender biases which clearly reflected by this table.

Moreover, the Table-3 stated that the literacy scenario among the people of West Bengal recently changed. Because if we follow the age group wise literate distribution, then the table clearly exposed the reason which refers the education rates develop from last one or two decades.

Finally, the Table-3 expressed that the age groups wise literacy distribution among male and females of Midnapore district of West Bengal, where, majority of the literate people both male (12.00%) and female (8.51%) exists in the age group of 10-14 years of age.

Here, the Table-3 also illustrate that increasing the age groups with decrease the literacy rates among both the males and females of Midnapore district of West Bengal; that means the educational development has been recently happened that's why the disproportionate relation between the age group and literacy rates.

Chart-2: Line diagram represents the percentage of literates over total population of Midnapore district

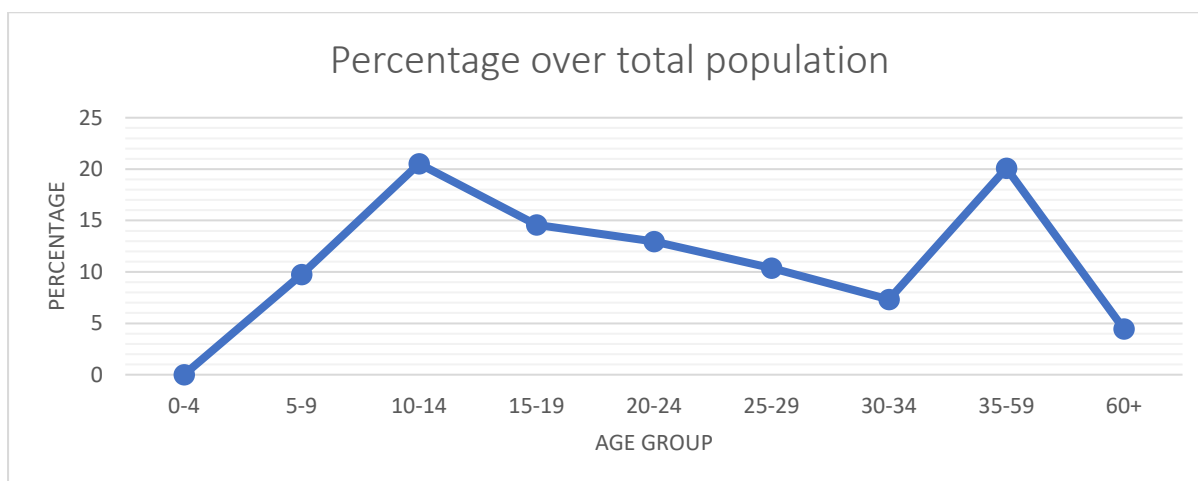


Table-4: Total literate population by age group in Darjeeling district

Darjeeling					
Age group	Total	Male	Percentage	Female	Percentage
0-4	-	-	-	-	-
5-9	45549	25026	5.76	20523	4.72
10-14	80830	46833	10.77	33997	7.82
15-19	67564	38938	8.96	28626	6.59
20-24	60197	36450	8.38	23747	5.46
25-29	47628	31862	7.33	15766	3.63
30-34	31893	22060	5.07	9833	2.26
35-59	86777	68148	15.68	18629	4.29
60+	14274	12058	2.77	2216	0.51
Total	434712		64.73		35.27

Source: Census of India, 1981, Series 23, part IVA, Social and cultural tables.

Table-4 presents the age group wise literate (here literate means literate without level of education, primary, middle, secondary, higher secondary, non-technical diploma, technical diploma and graduate and above) distribution of the total population of Darjeeling district of West Bengal. Out of the total population from all age groups

(except less than 4 years of age, because those ages child are not able for admission in formal education) 64.73% people are male and 35.27% of people are female among the total population of Darjeeling district, West Bengal.

Table-4 stated the male literacy is higher than the female literacy rates; which stated there have gender biases which clearly reflected by this table.

Moreover, the Table-4 stated that the literacy scenario among the people of West Bengal recently changed. Because if we follow the age group wise literate distribution then the table clearly exposed the reason which refers the education rates develop from last one or two decades.

Finally, the Table-4 expressed that the age groups wise literacy distribution among male and females of Darjeeling district of West Bengal, where, majority of the literate people both male (10.77%) and female (7.82%) exists in the age group of 10-14 years of age.

Here, the Table-4 also illustrate that increasing the age groups with decrease the literacy rates among both the males and females of Darjeeling district of West Bengal; that means the educational development has been recently happened that's why the disproportionate relation between the age group and literacy rates.

Chart-2: Line diagram represents the percentage of literates over total population of Darjeeling district

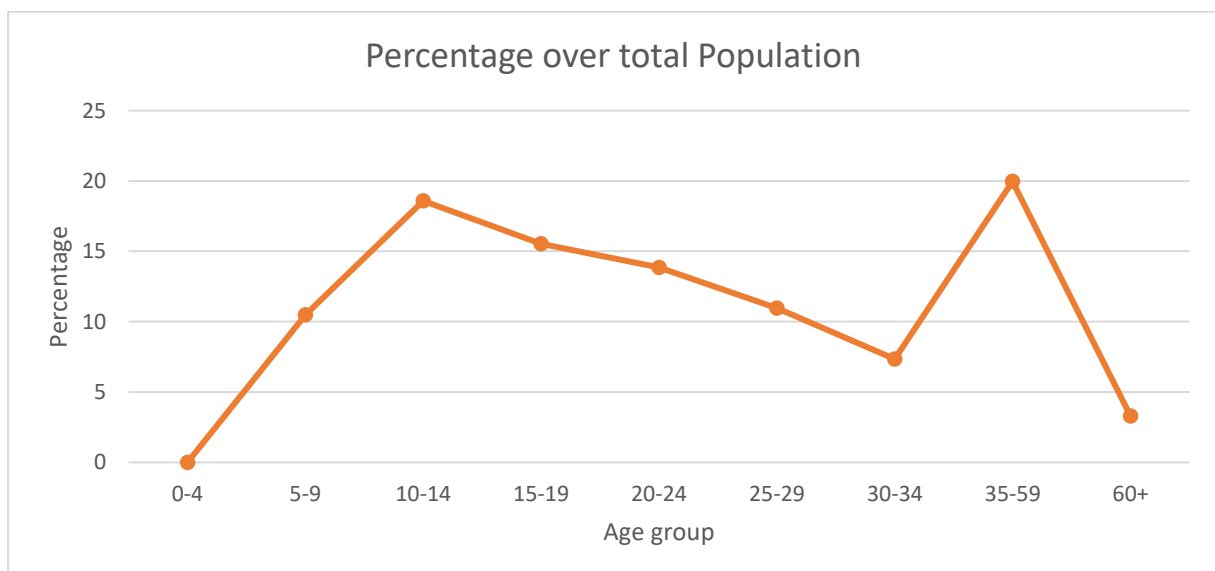


Table-5: Results of Examinations held by the West Bengal Board of Secondary Education and Council of Higher Secondary Education

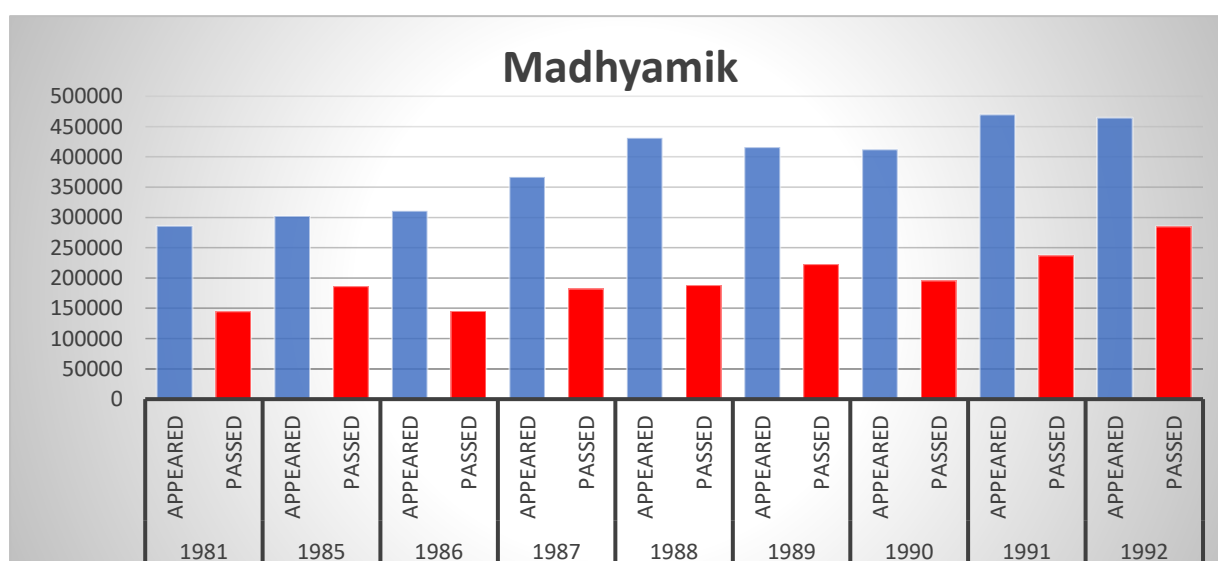
	1981		1985		1986		1987			
Name of the exam	Appeared	Passed	Appeared	Passed	Appeared	Passed	Appeared	Passed		
Madhyamik	286083	145010	302293	186461	310985	145566	366784	182409		
Higher Secondary	167001	78145	254650	129831	258883	112287	278024	98995		
	1988		1989		1990		1991		1992	
Name of the exam	Appeared	Passed	Appeared	Passed	Appeared	Passed	Appeared	Passed	Appeared	Passed
Madhyamik	431273	188314	416232	222902	412392	195851	470170	237246	464736	285125
Higher Secondary	259293	123655	262874	121815	280804	131802	308300	120093	291492	114066

Sources:

1. Board of Secondary Education, West Bengal.
2. Council of Higher Secondary Education, West Bengal.

Table-5 exhibits that the number of students who appeared and passed the Madhyamik and Higher Secondary exams from 1981 to 1992 in West Bengal.

Here, the Table-5 also illustrate that the number of students who appeared for both exams increased over the years, except for a slight dip in 1989 for Madhyamik and 1988 for Higher Secondary. The pass percentage of both exams fluctuated over the years, with the lowest being 46.8% for Madhyamik in 1986 and 43.4% for Higher Secondary in 1991. The pass percentage of Madhyamik was higher than that of Higher Secondary in every year except for 1981 and 1985. The highest pass percentage of Madhyamik was 53.6% in 1992 and that of Higher Secondary was 51.3% in 1985.



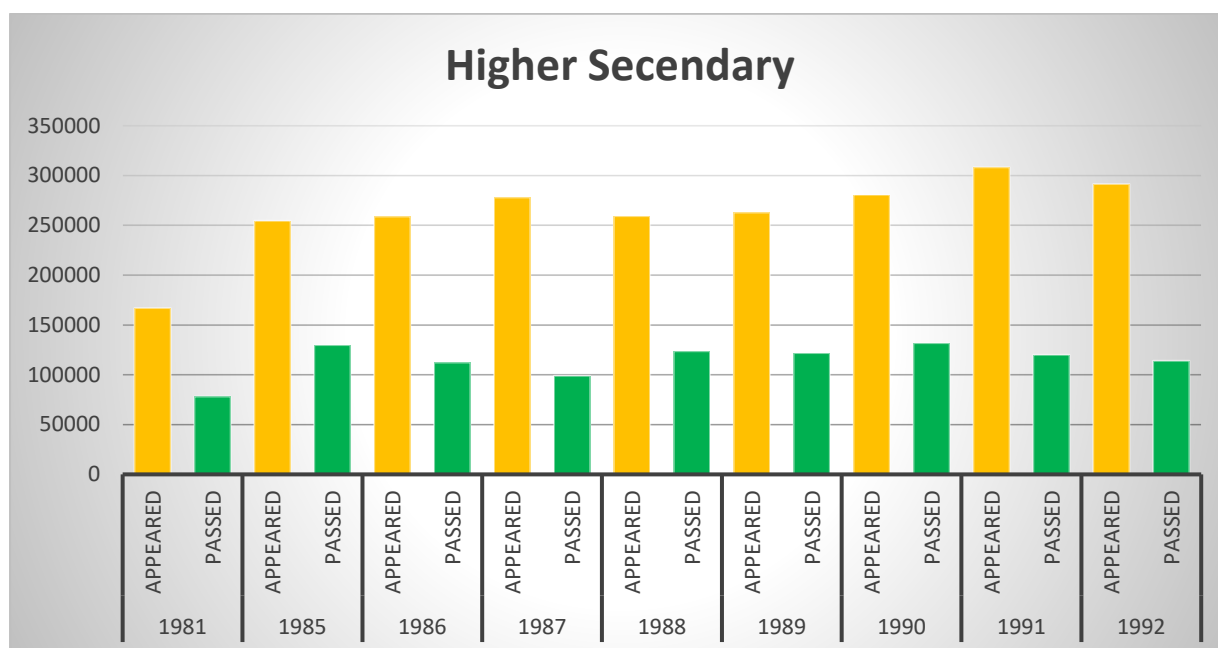


Table-6: Number of Scholars (General Education) in West Bengal by district

District	1987-'88				1988-'89				1989-'90			
	Primary	Middle	High	High Secondary	Primary	Middle	High	High Secondary	Primary	Middle	High	High Secondary
Burdwan	482245	47575	219549	81524	53564	54587	222515	98710	535364	55871	227614	103948
Birbhum	251626	26249	79871	40751	241706	26411	80482	43792		26249	81035	30472
Bankura	321076	26931	97084	46074	242602	17065	98127	46518	243509	18090	98206	46329
Midnapur	1354052	120354	281827	83388 *	1511851	122694	285003	85045	1472265	130531	316879	117935
Howrah	326905	88535	233932	71315	328905	95635	303875	72755	397202	79108	316116	81565
Hooghly	533451	21800	203908	76767	548310	24159	216172	813190	563451	47935	208277	76868
N_24-Parganas	498812	80840	317216	119266	568533	90273	334180	129840	618817	110510	346270	139880
S_24-Parganas	577708	78487	197062	56099	600478	57221	201003	81484	675859	58365	205023	83088
Calcutta	-	10192	130461	70531	-	11090	126311	71502	-	9534	129855	69532
Nadia	450325	60770	84975	-	412513	63072	145126	70489	420221	66056	152294	74076
Murshidabad	366890	28930	78268	43996	381351	30099	86000	43002	344377	31128	86815	44176
West Dinajpur	297487	26011	41300	32332	297949	18269	72502	27892	284693	20928	82595	28080
Malda	298188	25544	62723	17629	211603	335046	74409	46074	-	27474	99192	46554
Jalpaiguri	218607	12510	41492	26243	243246	14660	56200	30550	255304	15002	56367	30662
Darjeeling	169047	11141	39802	20049	169047	11141	39803	20049	-	-	-	-
Coachbehar	262224	18113	46577	29114	262944	17425	47265	30884	267980	17122	56553	30894
Purulia	206616	25947	49936	20926	210321	27086	50827	27819	227906	15508	51144	30580

*Incomplete

Source: Directorate of School Education, Govt. of West Bengal

Here, the Table-6 showing the number of scholars in West Bengal by district for the academic years 1987-'88, 1988-'89, and 1989-'90. It provides a breakdown of the number of students at Primary, Middle, High, and High Secondary levels. Based on the data, we can make some observations:

Here, the Table-6 also illustrate that the total number of scholars in West Bengal increased from 7,144,000 in 1987-'88 to 8,062,000 in 1989-'90, an increase of 12.8%. The district with the highest number of scholars in each year was Midnapur, followed by S-24-Parganas and Hooghly. The district with the lowest number of scholars in each year was Darjeeling, followed by Purulia and Coach Behar.

Moreover, Table-6 also stated that the academic level with the highest number of scholars in each year was Primary, followed by High and Middle. The academic level with the lowest number of scholars in each year was High Secondary, except for 1989-'90 when it was Middle.

Table-7: Distribution of Colleges in West Bengal by district

District	General degree Colleges	B.Ed/Ph. Colleges	Ph. Edn. Colleges	Law Colleges	Music Colleges	Art Colleges	Engg. Colleges	Tech. Colleges	Spl. Type of Intt.
Burdwan	12	1	1	-	1	-	-	-	-
Birbhum	10	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-
Bankura	22	1	-	-	-	-	-	-	-
Midnapur	65	4	-	-	-	-	-	-	-
Howrah	8	-	1	-	-	-	-	-	-
Hooghly	11	2	-	-	-	-	-	1	-
N_24-Parganas	22	3	1	-	-	-	-	-	-
S_24-Parganas	16	1	1	-	-	-	-	-	-
Calcutta	9	1	1	3	1	2	-	2	1
Nadia	5	1	-	-	-	-	-	-	-
Murshidabad	31	2	-	-	-	-	-	1	-
West Dinajpur	13	1	-	-	-	-	-	-	-
Malda	13	1	-	-	-	-	-	-	-
Jalpaiguri	10	1	-	1	-	-	1	-	-
Darjeeling	32	5	-	-	-	-	-	-	-
Coachbehar	21	1	-	-	-	-	-	-	-
Purulia	7	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-

Source: Annual report, 1992-'93, Department of Higher Education, Govt. of West Bengal

The Table-7 provides information on the number of different types of colleges in various districts in West Bengal. It includes General degree colleges, B.Ed./Ph.D. colleges, Higher Education colleges, Music colleges, Art colleges, Engineering colleges, technical colleges and Special types of institutes.

The Table-7 put light on the data about colleges that

- Midnapur has the highest number of general degree colleges (65), followed by Darjeeling (32) and Murshidabad (31).
- Calcutta has the most diverse types of colleges, with at least one in each category except for engineering colleges.
- Calcutta is the only district that has art college, and it has only one.
- Darjeeling has the most B.Ed./Ph.D. colleges (5), followed by Midnapore (4) and N_24-Parganas (3).

- Calcutta and Jalpaiguri are the only districts that have law colleges, and they have 3 and only one, respectively.
- Calcutta is the only district that has music colleges, and it has only one.
- Jalpaiguri is the only district that has an engineering college, and it has only one.
- No district has a special type of institute except Calcutta.

Table-8: Results of Calcutta University Examinations

	1985		1986		1987	
Name of the exam	Appeared	Passed	Appeared	Passed	Appeared	Passed
B.A. Part-I	6656	4450	7859	4952	7455	4621
B.Sc. Part-I	4997	2601	5459	2595	5788	2885
B.Com. Part-I	7078	4344	7225	5272	8250	5347
B.A. Part-II	4177	2918	4863	3472	5361	3680
B.Sc. Part-II	3297	2788	2975	2550	2712	2483
B.Com. Part-II	3788	2063	4416	2691	4502	2983
B.A. Pass	34460	18051	33793	16608	36294	16110
B.Sc. Pass	16395	8574	-	-	15454	6928
B.Com. Pass	28829	6947	32495	14888	29001	6533
	1988		1989		1990	
Name of the exam	Appeared	Passed	Appeared	Passed	Appeared	Passed
B.A. Part-I	7930	5072	7816	2729	7933	6155
B.Sc. Part-I	5093	3142	5354	1098	5675	3044
B.Com. Part-I	7787	4452	8940	6051	9836	7341
B.A. Part-II	5848	4128	5727	4131	5502	4242
B.Sc. Part-II	3233	2908	3617	3227	2901	2608
B.Com. Part-II	5644	3647	5256	3848	5074	3549
B.A. Pass	28818	13799	31330	14164	34302	15925
B.Sc. Pass	19772	6728	13219	6335	11757	5691
B.Com. Pass	25053	7999	24932	6026	25707	7211

Source: University of Calcutta

The Table-8 that provides information on the exam results of University of Calcutta in different parts of B.A., B.Sc., and B.Com. courses from 1985 to 1990.

Here, the Table-5 also illustrate about the following:

- The number of students who appeared for B.A. Part-I increased from 1985 to 1986, but decreased in 1987 (from 7859 to 7455) and 1989 (from 7930 to 7816) from their previous years. The pass percentage also decreased slightly over the years. The number of students who appeared for B.Sc. Part-I increased steadily from 1985 to 1987 and fall down in 1988 and then remain constant up to 1990, but the pass percentage remained low and almost constant. The number of students who appeared for B.Com. Part-I increased significantly from 1985 to 1987, and the pass percentage also improved in 1986, but dropped in 1987.
- The number of students who appeared for B.A. Part-II increased significantly from 1985 to 1988 and fluctuated from 1989 to 1990, but the pass percentage increased consistently. The number of students who appeared for B.Sc. Part-II

decreased from 1985 to 1987, but the pass percentage remained high and stable. The number of students who appeared for B.Com. Part-II increased from 1985 to 1987, but the pass percentage decreased drastically in 1987.

- The number of students who appeared for B.A. Pass fluctuated slightly from 1985 to 1987, but fall down severely in 1988. Although the pass percentage also decreased significantly from 1988 to 1990.

V. References

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